atmosphere of increased government reliance on computer databases, legislation rushed towards the absurd criminalisation of a plethora of computer use. What we saw with computer science was how quickly it allowed for a society of information-sharers, and this sharing, this society, exists in a greater condition of democracy and freedom than the traditional worlds of publishing and broadcasting. Freedom of information – and freedom *from* information – were quickly on the table, but the legislation has always struggled to understand what it might be asking the law to deal with and recognise. Given that ownership in the digital sense is not at all like ownership in the old physical sense of owning a watch, the legal world has failed to see what's in front of it. You don't steal information. You simply create a platform for it when it finds its way into the public realm. If I have a look at your watch, I'm not mugging you, I just want to know the time. Even by the mid-1990s, and even today, the legal establishment are none the wiser on how to consider the legal implications of our life with computers. That's why it took our Australian case so long to come to court.

Eventually, the trial came together in 1996. And all the while the struggle, indeed, was to be oneself – to go on and do the work you knew you could do and play your part. Opponents past and present have the same essential weakness about them: first they want to use you, then they want to be you, then they want to snuff you out. It's a pattern that stretches in my life from toytown Feds to hacks at the *Guardian*: the old human pattern of someone needing something from someone else, getting it, denying they got it from them, then resenting the person for having been in a special position to give them what they needed, which is usually, by the way, an aspect of self-hatred on the asker's part for having needed any help at all. Usually it ends with these people enumerating one's personal faults, a shocking, ungrateful, unmanly effort, to be filed under despicable in my book. You'll meet more of these people in due course, but I've been meeting them all my life.

The long wait for an arrest and a trial was one I wanted to use, and I was keen to see how I could discover more and more useful applications for the knowledge I had. Trax and I teamed up to form a computer security company and bought a massive mainframe computer from La Trobe University. It was quite funny to meet an old friend: this computer, the size of four fridges, one I'd hacked into years before. The security work basically involved me being paid to hack into the systems of large